camps at every stop (and it required tremendous patience and street-smartness to manage this twice every day for six months). It meant overcoming language barriers between civil society; it also meant keeping a microscopic watch on who was joining the Yatra under the civil society banner (which, given it was meant to be amorphous and open to all, represented challenges, since just about anyone could and did join. This meant doing rigorous background checks on the spot, lest antisocial elements join to disrupt the Yatra). And, of course, there was the problem of finding accommodation for civil society in the early stages of the Yatra. Despite these challenges, I am proud to say that each responsibility that was entrusted to us was shouldered diligently without any inconvenience or complaint to the non-Congress participants. This was because our primary mandate was to ensure that each person joining the Yatra felt welcomed, so they could eventually own the Yatra as their own (something the SBF leadership had strongly impressed upon all of us).

For each of these tasks to be successfully completed, we needed a streamlined nerve centre. Therefore our teams had dedicated mobile phones, emails and location-sharing technology to aid civil society. They proactively procured the Yatra's day-to-day schedule (including travel plans, distances, routes and designated resting locations), disseminated it to all civil society yatris, both already in the Yatra and wanting to join it through separate communication channels. This meant coordinating with the Congress party leadership that was organizing the Yatra the night before, and individual coordination with civil society yatris before the commencement of each Yatra. This was constant, gruelling work that placed a huge burden on both teams day after day. But it was done most judiciously.

The Beginning

I arrived in Kanyakumari from Ranchi via Thiruvananthapuram on 6 September 2022 and the commencement of the BJY started with Rahul